

The Body is the Unit: Migrant Commodification Through Deportation, Detention, and Transnational Carceral Exchange

Jon Nealon University at Albany, SUNY

Abstract

This paper develops a theoretical framework for understanding "migrant body commodification," the process by which state actors extract political, economic, diplomatic, and symbolic value from migrants through engineered legal precarity. Drawing on cases including Texas's busing operations, Florida's Martha's Vineyard flights, and the CECOT detention arrangement with El Salvador, the analysis identifies three distinct models of commodification: systematic (volume-based processing), spectacle (event-driven symbolic targeting), and transnational (offshore jurisdictional abandonment). The framework argues that legal uncertainty functions not as policy failure but as the primary mechanism enabling value extraction. When migrants possess clear legal status, their extractable value is limited; it is the deliberate maintenance of deportability, pending cases, and jurisdictional ambiguity that transforms migrant bodies into renewable resources. Empirical analysis reveals strong correlation between enforcement operations and electoral cycles rather than operational necessity, supporting the thesis that contemporary immigration governance has evolved into a sophisticated system for converting human beings into political and economic capital.

Full paper under review at Environment and Planning C: Politics and Space

For a working application of this framework, see The Commodification Lens at mbc-lens.onrender.com